

1701-1901

THE ASHANTI EMPIRE

The Ashanti Empire emerged in the 17th century in what is now Ghana. An ethnic sub-group of the Akan-speaking people, the Ashanti, or Asante, were composed of small chiefdoms established around Kumasi in the late 1600s. From 1701, Osei Tutu unified the chiefdoms and ruled as Asantehene (absolute monarch) of the most powerful political and military state on the Gulf of Guinea in West Africa. Gold was the Ashanti Empire's major product, with gold dust used as the circulating currency; even the poorest possessed gold ornaments. However, the Ashanti also became exporters of slaves, trading people captured during war raids on neighbouring enemies with the British, Dutch, and French

for luxury goods and, most importantly, firearms. This technological advantage allowed the Ashanti to build their empire, which reached its greatest extent under Opoku Ware (r. 1720-50) and stretched across central east and west Ghana and some parts of Ivory Coast and Togo.

Territorial expansion brought the Ashanti into conflict with the British, who had colonized Cape Coast, in the early 19th century. From 1824 to 1899, there were five wars between the Ashanti Empire and Britain and its allies. The British slowly gained the upper hand, capturing and burning Kumasi in 1874, and deposing and exiling the Asantehene, formally annexing the empire in 1900.



KEY MOMENTS

1701 Osei Tutu unites the Ashanti people

As king of the new Ashanti state, Osei Tutu's authority was symbolized by a Golden Stool. The stool was ritually cleansed every year as part of the Ashanti Yam festival (*left*), which marked the first yam harvest.

1720-50 Trade and expansion

Under Osei Tutu's successor, Opoku Ware, the Ashanti Empire expanded, contributing to a commercial network that spread north across the Sahara, trading ivory, kola nuts, and – most notably – gold, which was weighed using ornate weights (*left*).

1824-1901 Wars with the British

The Ashanti came into conflict with the British (*left*) after they claimed land belonging to the Fante – a prosperous British client state. Four more wars followed until the last – prompted by British disrespect of the Ashanti Golden Stool – resulted in a British victory and their dominion over the entire Gold Coast.

